

STUDENT GUIDE · BEGINNER FRIENDLY

AI Website Factory

Build a real, SEO-ready local website on your own laptop — research, design, write, and publish, all from one simple dashboard. No coding needed.



Step 0 — Download the project ZIP first

Get this before anything else, unzip it to your Desktop, then follow the setup in Section 2.

[↓ Download ZIP](#)

A complete, click-by-click guide to every feature. Keep this open beside the app while you work.

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1. What this tool does

The AI Website Factory is a dashboard that builds **local-business websites** for you with the help of an AI agent. You give it a business (name, niche, city). It then:

RESEARCH

Finds your keywords

Real search terms your customers type on Google — what to target.

DESIGN

Studies the best sites

Captures sections from top websites in your industry, so your design matches the winners.

WRITE

Generates the pages

Home, services, area pages and articles — written fresh for your business.

PUBLISH

Sends it to WordPress

One click deploys the finished pages to a live WordPress site.

THE BEST PART

It runs **on your own laptop** and uses your Claude Code subscription — so there's **no hosting bill and no per-use cost**. You build as many practice sites as you want, free.

2. Before you start — one-time setup

The app has two parts that must **both** be running, in two separate terminals:

PART	WHAT IT IS	COMMAND
The app (web)	The dashboard you click in your browser	<code>npm run dev</code>
The worker	The "engine" that does the AI jobs in the background	<code>npm run worker</code>

MOST IMPORTANT RULE

If the **worker is not running**, the app looks alive but **nothing finishes** — research, captures, and page generation all just sit there. Always start both.

First-time install (do once)

BEFORE THIS STEP

Make sure you've **downloaded the project ZIP** (link at the top) and unzipped it to your Desktop.

Open **PowerShell** in the project folder and run these in order:

```
# 1) Go into the project folder
cd "$env:USERPROFILE\Desktop\ai-website-factory-starter-2026-06-21\ai-website-factory-starter"

# 2) Download the app's parts
npm install

# 3) Create your settings file
copy .env.example .env

# 4) Make a long random SESSION_SECRET – copy the line it prints
-join ((48..57)+(97..102) | Get-Random -Count 64 | ForEach-Object {[char]$_})

# 5) Open .env in Notepad, fill the 3 settings below, then Save
notepad .env

# 6) Create the database + your admin login (prints email + password)
npm run db:seed
```

What to put in the `.env` file

Find these three lines in the file and set them exactly like this (copy-paste the two FACTORY lines as-is):

```
SESSION_SECRET=paste the random line from step 4
FACTORY_API_URL=https://app.growyourlimo.com
FACTORY_TOKEN=100022cde17ca18cce021b02d8f70f6d1c2334b20679ecdb
```

SETTING	WHAT TO WRITE
SESSION_SECRET	The long random line you generated in step 4 (keeps your login secure).
FACTORY_API_URL	<code>https://app.growyourlimo.com</code> (change it — the default <code>localhost:3001</code> is wrong)
FACTORY_TOKEN	The class token above — it unlocks keyword research. Same for everyone in the class.

COPY THESE EXACTLY

The `FACTORY_API_URL` and `FACTORY_TOKEN` values above are the shared class credentials — paste them as-is. Leave `GYL_WORKER_SECRET` as its default for now (you set the real one during worker setup below).

WINDOWS NOTE

Do **not** run `npm run db:reset` on Windows — it fails. Use `npm run db:seed` instead. To fully reset later: `Remove-Item -Recurse -Force .data\pglite` then `npm run db:seed`.

First-time worker setup (do once)

The worker is the second part (the AI engine). It needs its own settings file and a **secret** that links it to the app. Do this **after** the app is running (`npm run dev`) and you've logged in once:

1**Create the worker settings file**

```
copy .env.worker.example .env.worker
```

2**Find your Claude path**

```
(Get-Command claude).Source
```

Copy the path it prints, e.g. `C:\Users\You\.local\bin\claude.exe`.

3**Generate the worker secret**

With the app running, open localhost:3001/admin/agent/jobs and click "**Generate worker secret** →". **Copy** the secret it shows — you won't see it again.

4**Fill** `.env.worker`

```
notepad .env.worker
```

Set these two, then Save:

SETTING	WHAT TO WRITE
<code>GYL_CLAUDE_BIN</code>	The Claude path from step 2.
<code>GYL_WORKER_SECRET</code>	The secret you just generated (replace the default <code>dev-worker-secret</code>).

5**Start the worker**

```
npm run worker      # should say "polling for jobs" – and no 401
```

WHY THE SECRET?

The worker sends this secret to the app; the app checks it against its database. If they don't match you get **401 unauthorized** and every job stays stuck on "pending". `db:seed` does **not** create it — you must generate it once from the dashboard above.

Every time you use it (start the app)

Open **two** PowerShell windows in the project folder:

```
# Terminal 1 – the app
npm run dev      # wait for "ready" → opens on port 3001

# Terminal 2 – the worker
npm run worker   # should say "polling for jobs"
```

Then open your browser at <http://localhost:3001/admin>

TO STOP

Press `Ctrl` + `C` in each terminal window.

3. Log in

1

Open the app

Go to localhost:3001/admin. You'll be sent to the login page.

2

Use the seeded account

Type the **email and password** that `npm run db:seed` printed in the terminal. (If you lost it, run `npm run db:seed` again to see it.)

3

You're in

You land on the dashboard. The menu is on the left.

4. The dashboard map (left menu)

Everything lives in the left sidebar, grouped into four sections. Here is the whole map at a glance:

Websites

MENU

Connected sites

All the live WordPress sites you've linked. Click one to manage it.

MENU

◆ New website

Start building a brand-new site.

This is where you begin.

MENU**My day**

Your home screen — today's tasks and what needs attention.

MENU**Tasks**

Your to-do list inside the tool.

**Grow**

do these in order

STEP 1**Keyword research**

Find the search terms to target for the business.

STEP 2**Write content**

Create a page or article from a keyword (a "brief").

STEP 3**Content pipeline**

See all your drafts move from idea → written → published.

**Track & fix****MENU****SEO health**

A scorecard of how healthy your site is for Google.

MENU**Indexing**

Which pages Google has actually added to search.

MENU**Local SEO & GBP**

Google Business Profile and local-search signals.

MENU**SEO inbox**

Issues the tool found, waiting for you to review.

MENU

Fix queue

Fixes the AI is proposing — you approve, it applies them.

MENU

Alerts

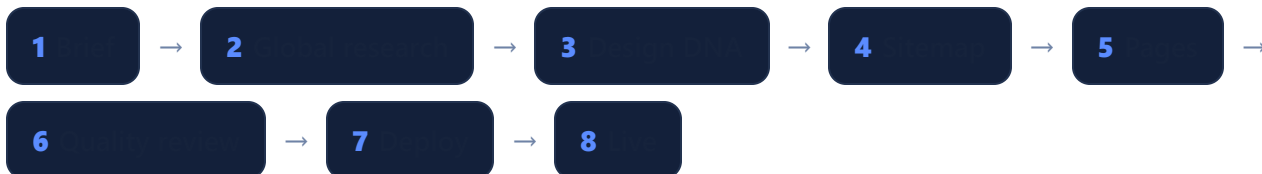
Warnings, like a sudden drop in Google clicks.

**System**[advanced](#) — collapsed by default

Click the **System** header to expand it. These are power tools you'll use less often: **Assistant** (AI chat helper), **Build agent**, **Research for new design**, **Per-page design**, **Core Web Vitals**, **Local-SEO rubric**, **QA Suite**, **Worker jobs**, **Reports**, **Users**, **Templates**, **Prompts**, **SOPs**, **Site budgets**, **Webhooks**, **Audit log**, and **Settings**. (Explained in section 11.)

5. The website journey (big picture)

When you build a new website, the tool walks it through **8 phases**. You approve each one before it moves on, so you're always in control:



PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS
1 • Brief	You answer a few questions about the business. This is your starting point.
2 • Global research	The agent studies the market and competitors for your niche.
3 • Design DNA	It decides the look & feel — colours, fonts, section styles. (You shape this in the Studio .)
4 • Sitemap	It plans which pages the site needs (home, services, area pages...).
5 • Pages	It writes the actual content for every planned page.
6 • Quality review	It checks the pages for SEO and quality problems before publishing.
7 • Deploy	One click sends the finished site to WordPress.
8 • Live	Done — your website is online.

6. Build your first website (step by step)

1 Click "◆ New website"

In the left menu under **Websites**. This opens a one-page form.

2 Fill the business details

Three things are required:

- **Business name** — e.g. *Bright Smile Dental*
- **Business niche / industry** — e.g. *dental clinic, gym, law firm, plumber*
- **Target city** — the city you want to rank in

Domain is optional — you can add it later.

3 Submit — research starts automatically

The moment you save, the agent queues the first research job. (Make sure the **worker** is running so it actually processes.)

4

You land in the project workspace

This is the page with the **8 phases** on the left and the current step on the right. You'll see the agent working, with a progress indicator.

5

Approve each phase

When a phase finishes, an **"Approve & continue"** button appears. Read what it did, then approve to move to the next phase.

WAITING?

AI phases take time. The page auto-refreshes. If it seems stuck, check Terminal 2 (the worker) — it shows what it's doing.

6

Shape the design in the Studio

Around the Design phase, open the **Site Builder Studio** (next section) to pick how each section looks.

7

Deploy

At the **Deploy** phase, connect a WordPress site (see below) and click deploy. Your site goes **Live**. 🎉

CONNECTING WORDPRESS (TO PUBLISH)

To put a site online you link a WordPress site once: left menu **Connected sites** → **Connect a site**. You'll enter the site's address and an application password. After that, "Deploy" can publish to it.

7. Site Builder Studio — design your pages

The Studio is a drag-and-drop screen where you choose how each **section** of a page looks, using real screenshots captured from top websites. Open it from a project: **Build** → your project → **Studio**.

What you see

TOP

Page-type tabs

Home, City, Service, Hub, About, Reservation.
Design each page type separately.

LEFT

Section list

Every section of that page (Header, Hero, Services, Fleet, Areas...). Turn on/off, reorder, and choose a design for each.

RIGHT

Live preview canvas

Your page builds in real time from the sections you pick. "This is how my page will look."

BUTTONS

Save & Lock

Save

keeps this layout.

Lock

applies it to *every* page of that type.

How to design a section

1

Pick a page type

Click a tab at the top (start with **Home**).

2

Turn sections on or off

Use the toggle on the right of each row. Required sections are locked on.

3

Choose a design for a section

Click **Choose** on a section to see captured design options (real screenshots). Click one, or **drag it onto the matching slot** on the right canvas.

4

Make a design "Global" (optional)

Click the  globe button on a section to make that design appear on **every page** (great for Header and Footer).

5

Save or Lock

Click **Save composition** to keep it, or **Lock ... design** → **all ... pages** to apply it everywhere of that type. Use **View full page** to preview the whole page.

IF YOU CAN'T DRAG ANYTHING

Dragging only works once you have **captured designs**. If every section says "*Default design*" and the canvas is empty, your design library is empty — you haven't run a design capture yet. The Studio will show a banner with a **"Start a design capture →"** button. Do that first (next section), then come back. The drag handle shows a  cursor when a section has no design yet — that's normal, not a bug.

8. Design research — fill the design library

This is what gives the Studio real designs to drag. Find it under **System** → **Research for new design** (or the banner button inside the Studio).

1

Start a capture

Choose a **market** (e.g. your city or country) and one or more **niches** (the industry). Click start.

2

The worker does the work

It finds the best sites in that market, then takes full screenshots and cuts them into sections (hero, services, fleet, etc.). Watch Terminal 2.

3

Wait for "captured"

When the run is done, the sections are ready in your library.

4

Load them into the Studio

Back in the Studio, click **Load finished research**. Now every section shows a "Best: ..." design and you can drag. 

WHY THIS MATTERS

Instead of guessing a design, you're copying the **layout** of proven, high-traffic sites — and the AI rewrites the content fresh for your business (no copied text or images).

9. Grow — keywords & content

Step 1 · Keyword research

Left menu **1 · Keyword research**. Type a topic or let it suggest terms for your business. You get real search terms with their search volume and difficulty. Pick the ones you want to target — they go into your **keyword bank**.

POWERED BY THE CLASS TOKEN

This uses the shared `FACTORY_TOKEN` in your `.env`. If keywords don't load, that token or `FACTORY_API_URL` is wrong (see Troubleshooting).

Step 2 · Write content

Left menu **2 · Write content**. Turn a keyword into a page. You give a short **brief** (what the page is about) and the agent writes a full, SEO-structured draft.

Step 3 · Content pipeline

Left menu **3 · Content pipeline**. Your content board. Every piece moves through stages — **idea** → **drafting** → **written** → **published** — so you always know what's done and what's next. The number badge on the menu shows items needing attention.

10. Track & fix your site

After a site is live, these tools keep it healthy. The AI finds problems; **you approve the fixes**.

TOOL	WHAT IT TELLS YOU / DOES
SEO health	An overall scorecard of your site's SEO. Red areas need work.
Indexing	How many pages Google has actually added. Not-indexed pages show the reason; the tool auto-submits them to speed things up.
Local SEO & GBP	Your Google Business Profile and local-ranking signals (reviews, map presence, NAP).
SEO inbox	A list of issues the tool spotted, waiting for your review. Badge = unread count.
Fix queue	The AI's proposed fixes (rewrite a page, fix meta tags, add internal links...). Approve to apply, or skip.
Alerts	Early warnings — e.g. a sharp weekly drop in Google clicks (a possible core-update hit).

HOW TO USE IT

Once a week: open **SEO health**, glance at **Alerts**, then clear your **Fix queue** by approving the safe fixes. That's it.

11. Advanced tools (System menu)

Click **System** to expand. You won't need most of these early on — here's what each one is, in one line:

TOOL	ONE-LINE MEANING
Assistant	An AI chat helper inside the dashboard — ask it questions about your sites.
Build agent	The build projects list (same as starting a new website).
Research for new design	Start/view design captures (covered in section 8).
Per-page design	Restyle a single existing page instead of a whole type.
Core Web Vitals	Real-user speed scores from Google (loading, responsiveness, stability).
Local-SEO rubric	A checklist that scores how well a page is optimised for local search.
QA Suite	Automated quality checks across the tool.
Worker jobs	Every background job and its status — the place to look when something is "stuck".
Reports	Summaries, including a weekly brief.
Users	Add or manage people who can log in.
Templates	Reusable page/section templates.
Prompts	The instructions the AI uses for each task (advanced — for tuning output).
SOPs	Standard operating procedures — saved how-to steps for your team.
Site budgets	Limits on spend/usage per site.
Webhooks	Connect the tool to other apps (advanced).
Audit log	A history of every change made, newest first.
Settings	App-wide settings.

12. Common problems & fixes

PROBLEM	FIX
I click "build / capture" and nothing ever finishes	The worker isn't running . Open Terminal 2 and run <code>npm run worker</code> — it must say "polling for jobs".
Worker shows 401 unauthorized / jobs stay "pending"	The worker secret is missing or wrong. Open <code>/admin/agent/jobs</code> , click "Generate worker secret" , paste it into <code>.env.worker</code> as <code>GYL_WORKER_SECRET</code> , then restart <code>npm run worker</code> .
In the Studio I can't drag sections	Your design library is empty. Run a design capture first (section 8), then click Load finished research . A  cursor on a section means it has no design yet.
Keywords won't load / error	Check <code>.env</code> : <code>FACTORY_API_URL=https://app.growyourlimo.com</code> and the correct <code>FACTORY_TOKEN</code> from your instructor.
<code>npm run db:reset</code> gives an error	On Windows use <code>npm run db:seed</code> instead. <code>db:reset</code> doesn't work on Windows.
I can't log in	Run <code>npm run db:seed</code> again and use the email + password it prints.
Page won't open at localhost:3001	Make sure <code>npm run dev</code> is running and shows "ready". Try the address again.
"running scripts is disabled" when running npm	Run once: <code>Set-ExecutionPolicy -Scope CurrentUser -ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned</code>
Something looks stuck	Open <code>System → Worker jobs</code> to see the job's status, and check Terminal 2 for the live log.

13. Daily cheat sheet

To start working

```
cd "$env:USERPROFILE\Desktop\ai-website-factory-starter-2026-06-21\ai-website-factory-  
npm run dev          # Terminal 1  
npm run worker       # Terminal 2 → "polling for jobs"  
# open http://localhost:3001/admin
```

The whole flow, in order

- ☐ ♦ New website → fill business name, niche, city
- ☐ Approve each build phase (Brief → ... → Deploy)
- ☐ Run a **Design capture** → Studio → drag designs → Save / Lock
- ☐ **1** Keyword research → pick keywords
- ☐ **2** Write content → **3** Content pipeline → publish
- ☐ Connect a WordPress site → Deploy → Live 🍌
- ☐ Weekly: SEO health → Alerts → clear Fix queue

Golden rule

👉 **The worker (Terminal 2) must always be running**, or nothing finishes.